In July 2015, the same month the JCPOA was signed, Beijing launched an effort to address Iranian concerns about BRI. The PRC embassy in Tehran held a high-profile celebration of the 88th anniversary of China's People's Liberation Army (PLA). In attendance were leading officials from Iran's ministries of defence, the military, and the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps (IRGC), along with China's entire Tehran diplomatic corps and top executives from Chinese firms active in Iran.[9] The IRGC was deeply involved in Iran's economy and had concerns, Lu Jin reported, about possible state security challenges related to BRI. In October, the Chinese Association for Friendship with Foreign Countries and the China–Iran Friendship Association had jointly held a conference in Beijing, with many influential Iranians invited to further discuss BRI. China's efforts at reassurance were successful. In September 2015, foreign minister Javid Zarif agreed during a visit to Beijing (apparently in preparation for Xi Jinping's upcoming visit) that BRI would be mentioned in a joint statement related to Iran's national development strategy. Iranian participation in BRI was extremely important, Lu Jin explained. Linking the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor to BRI projects in Iran could create a powerful symbiosis.

Xi Jinping, in January 2016, was the first foreign leader to visit Tehran once Iran's compliance with the JCPOA of the previous July was confirmed and the agreement to lift sanctions on Iran came fully into effect. Xi's visit was also the first by China's top leader to Iran since the one by Jiang Zemin in 2002, 14 years earlier, and as Washington was moving toward its regime change war in Iraq. Xi's objective during his 2016 visit was to build on the political capital China had acquired through its recent mediatory effort in the nuclear negotiations to further expand Sino–Iran cooperation. During Xi's visit, 17 agreements were signed and a number of joint declarations issued, including a 25-year agreement on comprehensive strategic partnership.[10]